

ROR STORY

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years, the whys and hows have been buried under a clamour of voices. Some people, of course, see justice in the Marxist action. Then there are thousands who are on the run, without any hope of being able to return or rebuild their homes. On November 13, CRPF personnel were allowed entry to the

RED MARCH: CPI(M) victory rally in Nandigram (left); protests in Kolkata area after a week-long detention on the national highway that leads to Nandigram. By then, CPI(M) had taken control of the troubled territory.

Unrest had been brewing in Nandigram since the last week of



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BUDDHADEB BHATTACHARYA, CHIEF MINISTER, WEST BENGAL

October. In retrospect, it was a carefully-executed plan by the masterminds at Alimuddin Street. The police would be asked not to enter the area and CPI(M)'s special cadres would then storm the *muktanchal* (open zone) of BUPC and take charge. The leaders in Kolkata couldn't afford to fail this time. So when Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya made his first public statement, there was no apology, no remorse in the voice of the man who once marketed himself as the human face of Indian communism. He said in uncharacteristic defiance: "They (Trinamool Congress people) have been paid back in their own coin. Our people were desperate. If hellish peace exists in Nandigram now, did the last 11 months have heavenly peace?"

Almost everyone who was not a Marxist condemned the savagery, beginning with Governor Gopal Krishna Gandhi. TC chief Mamata Banerjee, whose political advantage in Nandigram comes to an end with this takeover, has been touring the area on a motorbike. Even CPI(M)'s own allies, especially RSP, are debating whether to walk out of the Government, with state PWD Minister Kshiti Goswami threatening to resign. Intellectuals have already declared war on the Government. Historian Sumit Sircar says, "Even as a Marxist, I can't help criticising the atrocities, the repression, the attempts to grab peasants' land without adequate compensation. I don't think the salvation of the state lies only in industry, and if industrialisation happens, it should happen with the consent of the people, not by persecuting them, burning their land and raping and killing them."

Bhattacharya and his colleagues, meanwhile, are pulling out all the stops in defiance. The chief minister blamed the Maoists and said his party cadres took matters into their own hands when the Centre refused CRPF help earlier. Now the Government has to deal with a fresh wave of refugees who are too scared to go back home despite CPI(M) assurances that they will not be harmed. Most of them have no homes to return to.

What Bhattacharya cannot discount is the fact that the situation in the last 11 months has been of the state Government's own making. Last November, he announced that 27,000